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Phil Schaap

Phil Schaap was born in New York City on April 8, 1951. He grew up surrounded by jazz and its prominent players and began his career as a jazz DJ at WKCR in 1970. Phil has produced numerous recordings and is an important source of historical accuracy in jazz reissues. He has taught at Princeton and The New School and played an important role in Ken Burns' documentary "Jazz."

Phil was interviewed in Toronto, Canada on January 9, 2003 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Toronto for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm extremely pleased to have Phil Schaap with me here. I'm just going to call you a keeper of the jazz flame, and we can talk about the things you've done. You were just talking about, before the cameras were rolling, your teachers. And you mentioned Basie alumnus.

PS: Yeah, well alumni actually, Jo Jones, who the only people who called him Papa Jo Jones when I met him were his children, and some of them were pretty young. A couple of them were not born yet. And he was significantly younger than I am now. I am 51 and he was 44. That's significant. And Earle Warren, the leader of the reeds. I mean I don't know whether it was coincidence or because of their camaraderie, which once I intersected with it facilitated more Basieites being involved with the nurturing of me as a child jazz enthusiast into someone who could perhaps hand off some of the information they gave me to subsequent generations of largely listeners, not performers. But from the trumpet section Buck Clayton and less Sweets Edison, because when I was very young he moved to California so he wasn't a full timer but I knew Sweets well and he always was sweet to me. From the trombones, Dicky Wells and Eddie Durham and Benny Morton, I believe I met Benny last but perhaps heard him perform first. Then from the reeds Earle Warren, Buddy Tate. I met Lester Young a few times as a child but I didn't really have a relationship with him. I'm still close to his family, his widow Mary, and children, Lester, and in fact particularly Lester Junior but Mary Young more than any, who I met when I was five, when they were in the neighborhood when she got her library card at the Jamaica Public Library and my mother was — I believe she was the chief librarian by then but that wasn't such a big deal because I was sitting at her desk. There wasn't child daycare yet and the lady came in for a library card and it was Mrs. Lester Young so my mother said to Mrs. Young, "Oh is your husband the saxophonist in the Basie band?"

MR: And you were five?

PS: Yeah. Maybe four. Probably five.

MR: Okay. How come?

PS: It's a mid-fifties story.

MR: Yeah. How come?

PS: Because the music attracted me.

MR: At age four?

PS: And I had access to it.

MR: Yeah. Because of your father?

PS: Well why the music attracted me is probably something inside me that is not explainable. Why I had access to the music is probably a combination of my parents — let's not forget Marjorie Schaap — and the proximity of the musicians who were making jazz to the Hollis Queens neighborhood where we moved on December 4, 1956, although we moved into my mother's parent's home. They had been in Hollis going back a long ways, I mean to colonial times. So we're rooted, on my mother's side, in an area which became the bedroom community of jazz in the earliest of my scholastic years, I mean elementary school, and so on a daily basis it seemed — it couldn't possibly have been daily — but the people I had just found out about and become enthusiastic about instantaneously became neighbors. And that's really the formula.

MR: Oh that's great. I'm just trying to picture a four and five year old pursuing Basie albums and that kind of thing. That's a neat picture.

PS: Well enthusiasm among children isn't unusual, it's that I was enthusiastic about jazz that you're finding unusual. I probably was just as enthusiastic about sports at that time. I mean I could probably tell you as much about — at least statistically — about the major sports in those years as I could about jazz, as they were competing for my enthusiasms and jazz won somewhere in the middle of my adolescence. But every now and then a student of mine will be like from some city, let's say Pittsburgh, and I'll tell them everything about the Pittsburgh Pirates from roughly 1950 to 1965 maybe or 3, and then it will disappear and they won't understand it you know. Why does it disappear? And the answer is because I'm teaching you jazz.

MR: I see. Was the swing-based music of the Basie band something that your parents liked too?

PS: Oh they were huge Basie enthusiasts, but that doesn't mean they weren't huge Benny Goodman enthusiasts, huge Fletcher Henderson enthusiasts. I would say that — I would say they didn't have a Basie preference to my knowledge. I would say that my befriending more Basie alumni than say the Ellington people — remember the Ellington

New York City, much less residents of the Hollis area. I knew Russell Procope well but he was largely gone. I eventually became quite close to Sam Woodyard, but this was later. I mean then it was the Basieites, and then through me having these unusual extra-parental associations I would say that my parents became more Basie core because when I emerged professionally that's my first idea was a group of these Basie alumni playing the early Basie repertoire, to give some context to these gigs, and to play repertoire that Basie himself was largely no longer using.

MR: For you what was it about the Basie sound that made it distinctive?

PS: Well that it's an orchestra that is able to incorporate, without everyone being a genius, the rhythmic revolution of the 1930s. But I don't think I could have told you that in 1956. I mean in other words the suppleness of the beat that is elasticising and making more fluid the energy of swinging jazz rhythm.

MR: Is that the rhythmic revolution?

PS: That's what I'm calling the rhythmic revolution of the thirties. There's an innovation of genius. Roy Eldridge, Billie Holiday, Charlie Christian, Benny Carter, Benny Goodman, Teddy Wilson, Lester Young if I haven't said him of course, and a few others. But the transference of it to others and the coherence of it as an ensemble display where the parts are combinable and examinable separately, I hear that merger in the Basie band first, other than an individual display. Billie Holiday displayed it on her lonesome, but the Basie band displayed it as an aggregation. And I think that that attracts me and clinches or adds musical substance to an emphasis that I place — because I knew, I mean Buddy Tate, of the inner core musicians who raised me and trained me, I mean I was fortunate in that none of the primaries died until I was nearly 30. I would say Russell Procope was the first close friend, extra family, extra father, to die and he died in January of '81 and I was 29 in January of '81, so I was pretty lucky in that regard considering how wide open I was to such setbacks and emotional challenges. And then with Buddy Tate's death in February of I guess 2001, I lost the last one. It doesn't mean that they are different than the musicians who I can't say that about it's just that they had hands on operation with me as a child and that I formed these bonds and now I'm kind of out on my own.

MR: Right. How did you find them overall as people?

PS: Well everybody's different. And I can separate their identities. I believe there is a reason why Basie got these groups together. I believe they are individuals who created a connectable core to each other. I find the camaraderie of the Basie guys, it's a moot point now except maybe in some larger sense, but there was a buddy system there that's different from — but they're all different. Eddie Durham for instance, probably was musically the most smart, best trained, clearly a genius. I would go so far to say that

first electric guitarist. He arranged “In the Mood” for Glenn Miller. He wrote the original Basie band book. He taught all these people. He wrote “Topsy,” he co-wrote the “One O’clock Jump” he really created the formula and he was very, very — not so much introverted as incredibly quiet and had no arguing desires in his make-up. I used to have these things I would mention to Eddie and he would tweak them for me. In a sense he would correct me, and then I would stick with my answer. And he would say, “Okay, Phil.” But of those, there’s only one left in which he was not right and I was not wrong. And I believe (a) that I am right, which would be the only time, which is a small point because there were thousands that he was right about, and (b) I’m not positive it’s provable but he still thinks — is it “Pigeon Walk” or is “Posin” it’s one or the other, it’s probably “Pigeon Walk,” by the Lunceford band, recorded in Los Angeles in the fall of ’37. He still thinks it’s he, the guitarist, and not Allen Norris on it. But he’s not on that record. And I believe that what Norris had done is taken the lessons and was able to, in this one instance, fake out the creator to think that it was himself. But staying on line with “Pigeon Walk,” when I first found this record, which you had to find, I believe on 78 it’s so long ago, or — I don’t think my father and mother had that in their collections. I had their libraries and my additional library. And I’ve got a lot of 78s when — remember the LPs demise and the CDs struck so LPs got real cheap. Well when they were clearing out the shelves of the 78s it was the same deal. I bought a lot of them by the pound. There was one record store, Triboro Records in Jamaica Queens that just had a little scale for 78s and they got rid of them man. They wouldn’t charge anything. And I actually, recognizing that the vinylite 78s of post World War II both weighed less and sounded better. Therefore one could get more records at this thing. I think that’s really where the start of my bebop interest is rooted. Because I suddenly had many more bebop 78s than my father or mother would have had. They would have few, and I suddenly had an out of balance percentage at this early juncture. Plus Russell intersected favorably with me at the age of four or possibly five, but I think it’s four because we were still living in Astoria, an area of Queens where we had an apartment before my grandfather retired and my father and mother bought the house and they went to Florida, we moved to Hollis. But Ross Russell was friendly with my parents and when he closed down the warehousing of the defunct Dial Record Company — I guess he had gone broke is what happened because he’s staying — you know there’s my bed and there’s a rollaway cot and it’s Ross Russell in our apartment, that doesn’t really sound like you have a nice luxurious little staying place here in a nice hotel. New York City has nice hotels but he’s staying and my parents I think took it as a holiday to go out and date a lot, with themselves I mean, because —

PS: Right. And he let me watch "The Tonight Show" which I think had just started, which had a lot of jazz on it then. He let me stay up as late as possible.

MR: Yeah, they had a heck of a band.

PS: So I have fond memories — this is the Steve Allen days if I'm not — I mean it's either Steven Allen or pre-Steve Allen. I think it's Steve Allen. And — definitely it was Steve Allen. And Ross Russell left behind a stack of yellow labeled Dial 78s for me which got mixed in with the Golden records and my Lester Young 78 and the ones that I — and so I have fond recollections. It's sometimes hard for me on the air to point out that he's guilty of many outright fictions when he clearly could have known better in writing his histories.

MR: Yes. Well as a teenager, you had this —

PS: Oh I didn't finish the Durham thing, I'm sorry.

MR: Oh okay, go ahead.

PS: So Eddie Durham, so I got this "Pigeon Walk" which is what set us off on this course. I got it and I immediately noticed, hey, that's the introduction to "Time Out," which, and they're both written by Eddie Durham. So I said well there's a match. So I had met Eddie Durham so I ran with the record. You couldn't make it on a cassette, although reel-to-reel tape existed I didn't have access yet. I got one of those in '61. So this is probably '61 or earlier. And although this conversation happened again and again, and I said, "So Eddie, you know, it's the same thing." He said, "I got in a lot of trouble over that." And then he said, "And you know and there's even a third title, Phil, the original title, we didn't call it 'Time Out' we called it 'Count Nine.'" And I said "Count Nine?" So I listened to the introduction of "Time Out" and being not just inferior to Eddie Durham but just an inferior musician, I counted ten. So I said "Don't you mean 'Count Ten' Eddie?" He said, "Okay Phil." The point was he had had this earlier thing. But now I can't even re-teach myself how to get it to ten. It's count nine. He's right, I'm wrong. This would be the first of the — I don't know whether you've ever gotten Dan Morgenstern before this —

MR: I have not.

PS: But if you do, and you choose to bring this up it would be a small point in his life, "You Got Love" is a very obscure 1931 Benny Moten record which he purports, and he's a very wise man, I mean this is no challenge to Dan Morgenstern's magnificence and his majesty, but he says that that's an uncredited Hot Lips Page vocal, the first Hot Lips Page vocal known. And you listen to the record and it makes a hell of a lot of sense. I played it for Eddie Durham and he states it's Jimmy Rushing. It's not Jimmy Rushing.

MR: Yeah you can tell Jimmy Rushing, can't you?

PS: Oh, then you play the game and you make your own choice then you come back and

it's Jimmy Rushing." "It's Lips." And then he said, "Okay" and he never would debate it again with me because to get him to go three or four times was unusual. He must have either liked me or disliked me, because he's going the extra yard. And it's Jimmy Rushing. I'm wrong. No longer wrong. If Dan still says it's Lips he's — look out Dan — wrong. And Eddie Durham is once again — he completely backed off and didn't mean anything, but he was right.

MR: But how did you finally determine that?

PS: I learned it. You know this is the punch line of studying for a lifetime. I know now. I'm not anywhere near Eddie Durham but I'm better than I was when I was eleven. And it's Jimmy Rushing. That's Jimmy Rushing singing "I Need That Love," not Lips Page. Eddie Durham, as I said, there are like sixty of these little things and obviously I can't give them all to your camera but of the sixty — so all sixty I thought I was right, all sixty I thought Eddie Durham was wrong. As it stands now Eddie Durham is right 59 times. I'm wrong 59 times and the one outstanding issue which I do pache Eddie Durham's soul, I do believe this time Eddie is wrong, which is "The Pigeon Walk." If it is "The Pigeon Walk," I think it's "Pigeon Walk" and the guitar solo by Allen Norris. It's a Hollywood recording I believe from November 15 of '37 and Eddie Durham couldn't have been there.

MR: I see. Well I hope you get to keep that one.

PS: I hope I lose it.

MR: That means you're still learning.

PS: It does. It also means Eddie Durham is as great as I say he is, and he is. So it was Eddie Durham in the trombones and Benny Morton and Dicky Wills. I wasn't too close with Vic. Vic was kind of shy I betcha. And to get children into his inner circle, he liked to talk to musicians and adults. And so, and I had such a friendship with Dicky Wells that took me all around. Dicky is my meal ticket, my ace — and he was so brilliant. Dicky Wells was wise too but Eddie Durham was the genius and wrote all that stuff. And then Earle Warren led the reeds. And he was the one I was closest to, because he was the leader and he was a teacher and he was a father. He did something that — I don't know how much teaching you do but he did something with young people that I'm still trying to do, much less do as well. He's the only one I've ever seen do this. I talk with Wynton Marsalis a lot about this because he doesn't know — he knows Earle Warren but didn't realize that if he led the reeds in that band he must be great. And I was asleep on him, so tell me about him. You know so like that's really my function. I hung out with Earle Warren for 35 years and you get to hear about it because you can. That's the formula. That's why this is such a great thing that's going on. If any of this is great and if I can

of his musical greatness — was that you know adolescents are rebellious. They're not necessarily political or socially oriented. I mean I think the youth movement concept is a little bit overrated. It happened in my generation in America and perhaps even internationally but it doesn't always happen. But rebelliousness and fighting off the direction and wisdom, pontifications of the elder generation, that battle ground has been around, according to Aristotle, at least 3000 years, and Earle Warren is the only person who when it's a cold line in the dirt, you're on that side and I'm on this side, you're the young person and Earle Warren, and he could say "listen I understand where you're coming from, let me explain this to you." And do it. And explain it so that everything calms down and that he could explain to the student or youngster why they were wrong, get them to accept it, to understand that it wasn't just some browbeating coming down from on high, and to adapt it in some way, to synthesize it. And I've never seen anyone do it as well as Earle Warren did it. Absolutely outstanding ability to explain a complete difference of opinion over a generation gap and win — it's not a competition, he knew that — to explain it. And to find common ground and good action from both sides.

MR: Quite a talent.

PS: I've never found it again. I'd like to have it. And let's not leave out Jo Jones, the original, the babysitter, you know I was going to Jo Jones' apartment learning jazz lessons from Jo Jones, it's a tough struggle, but I knew him and he was great.

MR: What kinds of things did he teach you?

PS: How to listen to records so you didn't say something stupid. That's an important lesson. Him and Al Hibbler. Say, "Monk, who do you think's playing alto on this record?" And you'd say, "Well I don't know." "You can't tell, Monk?" "No I can't." "Well tell you what. Here's the record. Listen to it for a week. Come back next Saturday morning. But if you can't tell me next Saturday morning give me back the record and don't come here no more." Now that's a tough teaching — their method. I hope I'm not that mean. But they weren't mean to me.

MR: I see. Were your parents thrilled that you were getting this?

PS: Yes. No. My mother was eventually thrilled. She was fighting the sports and music thing. I mean her idea was — I wanted to learn an instrument and it was violin or nothing so I said nothing.

MR: She said violin or nothing.

PS: Yeah. She may not — I may be making her out to be more shrewish, she was a zany Bohemian jazz lover. But she didn't want — I guess she wanted the best for me and she had to figure out what the best was at the time. So I got involved in singing with my boy soprano in the major music program of the New York City public school system which

program and the enriched program — they call it SPE — or they called it I gather, I have no idea whether it still exists in the New York City public school system. But SPE is a special program for good, gifted students. But the E meant there'd be some music component. Enriched is what it stood for. And you either went into the band or you went into the chorus. And I wanted that band bad. But I'd been singing on an enriched music program with this boy soprano fourth, fifth and sixth grade because I had done okay on the recorder class, they give you some recorder lessons and I did okay, so and then I passed some listening test which probably I shouldn't have passed because I'm not that good. And they wouldn't let me take an instrument. So I started studying trumpet on the side on my own in adolescence. But my mother, my grandfather, her father, was an excellent musician, an organist, a church organist, but he was a lawyer. And my father's father was a lawyer. And lawyer — they discovered this memory, you know when I was two I could do the presidents, forward and backward, with their dates. I still can do it but I do it slower than I did in 1953. And it's not just because there are more presidents since Truman, it's that some of them are more forgettable than Truman. And you know so she wanted that. And I loved those Brooklyn Dodgers and — "You don't take my son to baseball games" she really didn't want me to go to the sports things. And fortunately for me if thwarting that is important, was that my illustrious cousin, you know, hit big time sports right then and started like free ticket city. That would be Dick Schaap. He died just slightly more than a year ago. And he went with *Newsweek* and *Sport Magazine* right around the time I entered elementary school and the next, until he was city editor of the *Herald Tribune* which would be like '63 or '4, it was sports heaven in a Schaap house, any Schaap household. I mean what does Billy Crystal say? They're pretty tight, Billy Crystal and my late cousin were very tight, he says, "What is the first thing you think of when you think of Dick Schaap?" "Tickets." And boy he wasn't in the family. And it's funny, you know during that time I knew Billy Crystal's father. He stunned — I mean Billy Crystal is close friends of this area of our family, the Schaap family, they are tight. But I knew Jack Crystal and Bernhardt Crystal, Jack's brother, who still lives. And I've only met Billy Crystal and spoken with him largely about his father. And I actually have something that Billy Crystal wants from me. I have — Jack Crystal used to let me into the Central Plaza for cheap. I don't think he let me in for free, but he let me in for cheap. And Billy Crystal said, "Did you save the ticket stubs?" And my mother was half pack rat and half insane throw outer. So the autograph collection and the programs, my Scotty LaFaro autograph and all the others, it's gone. But one ticket stub, I must have put it in the wrong place, from the Central Plaza. And he wants the Central Plaza ticket stub. I always said this Dixieland club, very close to where the Filmore was a few years later

brother-in-laws — but he got out of the Commodore Music Shop. And he was nice to me. Jack Crystal was nice to me. And Billy Crystal liked that, and Dick Schaap liked that because it was so odd, and Bernhardt, he can't believe, I'm the only guy he meets who doesn't know his famous nephew and does know his late brother.

MR: Oh really. But your father liked the fact that you had all these associations with these musicians.

PS: Yeah my mother did too. I mean we went to the events. But the person who I'm leaving out from a family thing is that so my father and mother took me to these things, and I went out and then the musicians took me to some of these things. But my cousin Bill, Bill Schaap, Dick's younger brother, he stepped into the breech and started, I piggy backed on his enthusiasms and goodness. I mean he's a good guy. His wife stopped answering the telephone because I took him out of the house and I guess she didn't like jazz. He took me to see everything. We even booed Dylan at Gerde's Folk City, which wasn't called Gerde's yet, it was just Folk City. I think it was before they took over Tony Pastor's joint, before they moved. And the only reason why I know it was Dylan who we booed is because he became famous so quickly after. Because they would have the new folk singer who wanted to be the next Pete Seeger I guess or Dylan would probably say Woody Guthrie. And they would be the emcee but they would do a few songs at the start of the show. And I really wasn't into — there was this Hootenanny craze.

MR: Yes, sure.

PS: So we're in the same tribe, huh Monk, yeah, yeah, yeah? You seem to know as much about the fifties and sixties.

MR: Yeah, we're very close.

PS: But it was cool with me but it wasn't cool. And so if you wanted to go to Folk City to see a blues act, because they had blues acts, like Sonny Terry, who was my neighbor. I used to hit home runs, whiffle ball into his yard. I think he lived at the corner of Keno and Pompey in Hollis. And we didn't want to hear this unknown folk singer do his thing, so you booed him to make sure he didn't do an encore or anything.

MR: Really.

PS: Oh yeah. It didn't matter whether it was Dylan or not. Whoever it was you booed.

MR: Oh. Okay.

PS: Let's say this was the bill. You know, I'm not saying this was the bill, you have Joan Baez, Pete Seeger, Peter, Paul & Mary, Benny Goodman and an unknown folk singer. And so if I went to that, I went to hear Benny Goodman. Even though Peter, Paul & Mary and Joan Baez and all these others are famous people, I'll tolerate them because they're famous, I want to hear what they have to do, but I'm going to be sitting on my hands for

McGee which I went to see many times. That's what I want to see. So I'm not going to encourage an encore. I'm trying to get rid of this thing. But because he became famous so fast I remembered it was him.

MR: Sure. Well he had a pretty distinctive sound at the time too.

PS: Yeah but that wasn't it, it was just he was the guy and you booed him. I booed others whose names I don't know. I know him because he became famous. Every time I went to Folk City it was to see the blues act. Never once to see the folk act. Not once. It doesn't make them bad, it doesn't hopefully make me bad. But I went to see the blues act. And so the new hootenanny wannabe who was the emcee got short shrift from me, and my cousin Bill, and at one time it was Dylan.

MR: Okay. Well when you got to be 17, 18 thinking what kind of outlet is there for this passion I have—

PS: Yeah. I thought about it a lot, surprisingly a lot. I scoped out what I wanted to do pretty quickly and stuck to it very seriously. I mean for a minute there I wanted to be a trumpet player. I got a trumpet and I practiced too much, as my neighbors I'm sure could tell you, and I got a little bit of facility in the upper register, but I played stupid. And I was smart enough to know I was playing stupid. When I played with rock & roll bands, you know, I just recently ran into this guy, he actually had a minor career in big time rock & roll, Lou Erlanger. I think he goes as Lou X. Erlanger. He was with Mink Deville and a couple of other things. But they had a band called the Stingrays. And I helped them. Because they were good. And they thought I was good. And they were wrong. And I'm still wondering what on earth — and I recently met Lou again for a jazz reason I'm pleased to say and you know he still remembers that he dug me. Because I swung better than they did, no offense, Lou and his band, the Stingrays. And they were encouraging me. But I was impressed at their facility on their instruments and their intonation. They were better on electric guitar than I was on trumpet, and they played in tune. I had an upper register on trumpet but I had a shrill tone and I got excited and I played woefully out of tune, sharp largely, which I can hear. Good enough to hear it, not good enough to stop. So I stopped playing. And the other reason why was because of my sound career. I made a few gigs at a place called the McGill House in Jamaica, Queens. This was — I mean from my point of view I mean I was doing nothing. We played, a trombone player, a tenor player and me, we'd play a chord behind some singer trying to be the next Diana Ross. She wasn't that famous yet, there was just the Supremes. Or something like that. And that was the gig. And then downstairs — it was really actually a very well run operation. Downstairs they had like, it was more like Gerde's Folk City. It wasn't so much the hootenanny thing but the protest folk music thing which is a little more

and I'm sure I was attracted to a couple of young females who I went to high school with down there. But I was playing with the rhythm & blues, or soul as it was starting to be called, upstairs. And the sound was good. And I used to talk to the sound guy. And then I'd go hear Roy Eldridge, that was say a Saturday night dance on Sunday I'd say, "Roy, you know the sound isn't too good." He said "I'm hip, tell me about it, please believe me I need help." And gradually I became an audio guy. And this really, I think, triggered the idea of helping the musicians who deserve to be helped rather than becoming an undeserving musician. And that transition occurs over the late 60s and basically my Columbia college years. And I'm out of the trumpet business. Well I played Milestones at the West End on March 11, 1974 with Paul Quinichette and Matthew Gee, and Sam Woodyard. And I was playing Frank Williams' horn so he wasn't playing. I don't know who was on piano. It might have been Frank Williams, he had good piano playing. Or that might have been it. There may have been no chordal root. But we were playing a modal piece so that makes sense. There was no chordal root. And then Gee and Quinichette, who pache, their souls were drunks, they laid out on the bridge you know, and I think there's an E above the staff you've got to hit twice in the bridge [humms], there was just me out in the open, me and Woodyard. And I said I'll never do that again in life. And I haven't. I did play my notes right then, and so I said I'm batting a thousand, time to retire.

MR: Right. Well you got into the radio through Columbia University.

PS: Absolutely. And through my sound career. But when I got to Columbia most of the people in Furnald, the dormitory I lived in, they didn't really know what I was playing but they knew it wasn't what they were used to listening to and they vaguely understood it was jazz and everybody kept saying that I should go see Jamie Katz, who lived, well I was on 1006 Fernald and he lived in, like it was interconnected, I think it was 732, 33, 34. They reconfigured the doors but not the rooms in that building so it's all moved now anyway. But he was down on the seventh floor. And one night I went down there and I knocked on his door and he blindfold tested me. So the first thing he played — actually he almost could have got me but I knew it, I knew it was McCoy. So I says, "That's McCoy Tyner." He said, "Pretty good." He says, "I'm going to give you a hard one now." And then he played — I even know the record he was playing, I told him I knew the record. I didn't see it, I mean he was blindfold testing me, but it was Count Basie with Bennie Moten's band. I mean it was sort of like "The Briar Patch Story." So I said, "Well that's Count Basie playing a little combination Fats Waller and four hands in his early records with Benny Moten's Kansas City Orchestra, of 'Jones Law Blues' and 'Small Black'" and that was — so then he says, "now I'm going to play you another record" and

the others because you seem to know the stuff." So he puts on "Further Definitions" Benny Carter, Impulse Records and so I said, "The piano player, that's Dick Katz." And he goes, "How do you know that." I said well "Richard Aaron Katz, March 13, 1924, Baltimore Maryland, played a lot with Tony Scott and was well known for association with Orrin Keepnews and Milestone Records and I don't know whether he had started his association with Helen Merrill at that time but if he had I would have known about it and I would have said something. And he's on Benny Carter's 'Further Definitions' records and also played with Buck Clayton at the Newport Jazz Festival," which I should have said actually he played with the J.J. Johnson band at the Newport Jazz Festival. They happened to make a record with Buck Clayton. But that's how I knew him from that period. And then I said, "Of course he's Roy Eldridge's piano player." And I stopped with that. And he said, "Oh yeah, that's my father."

MR: Oh it was Dick Katz's son, oh my.

PS: Which is why he was—

MR: Okay well then you were winning some points. But you didn't know it at the time.

PS: No. Katz is a very common last name, K-A-T-Z is a common last name in New York City. I wasn't thinking what Jamie's last name was anyway, I was thinking I've got to get these questions right.

MR: I see.

PS: So I said who Dick Katz was and there I was.

MR: Wow. You know I'm curious, does this encyclopedic knowledge of yours, when you were in high school did it work in other venues too?

PS: It still does.

MR: Like social studies?

PS: Oh sure man. What do you want to know about American history?

MR: Okay. I'm just curious.

PS: Do you want me to do the vice presidents for you?

MR: I don't know, how much tape do we have?

PS: Yes I'll talk you to death. That's another problem with this memory. I'll talk you to death. Guilty as charged. I did well in school and in fact my jazz interests were saved because I was ready to have my academic career plummet, you know, due to my complete devotion towards jazz, which merges head and shoulders over anything else in my junior high school years. It makes me both an outlaw and an outcast. And I felt that the dues that this was going to cost me would be catastrophic in terms of the goody two shoes, straight ahead, you know, super high grades college thing. And you know I had a 99 average and I stopped going to school, stopped doing my homework, came and took

MR: Did the music, let's say the AM rock of the time, have any impact on you at all?

PS: Yeah. I liked it a lot. Not so much maybe AM. Remember, my guys were playing for Allen Freed and loved him.

MR: Yeah, that's true.

PS: Big Al Sears, who we haven't mentioned since I gave short shrift to the Ellingtons, let's not forget Big Al Sears. He was great. And to spend another second in his basement if it rains or in his backyard if it's not, would be heaven. I would even trade you one of my rarer records for just one second of that in real time again. The food from Ruth Sears, who still lives, although like she doesn't cook up a feast anymore, I think she's like ninety something. But she still lives in the house. And Big Al Sears had gone into the record business and become quite an executive, and it was rock & roll. And he was wonderful to me. I'm glad to have something nice to say about rock & roll, it made me mention Big Al Sears in a jazz interview.

MR: Well it's great because a lot of those fellas would get work in the studios even, playing.

PS: Yeah. Heywood Henry is on "I Put A Spell On You" and that's the first time he ever—

MR: What was that?

PS: Heywood Henry of the Erskine Hawkins band [scats] they had to rent a bass saxophone for him to play that. That's a bass sax.

MR: Oh that's a bass sax.

PS: Being played by a great baritone saxophonist.

MR: I'll be darned. Well after we're done I have to ask you about if you know who a certain saxophone player is.

PS: Okay.

MR: But at any rate—

PS: Yeah I'll let you run the show for this here. We're running out of tape.

MR: You've got a show — were you pretty much at liberty to play what you wanted?

PS: Complete liberty. That's why I'm still there.

MR: Because if someone was telling you—

PS: Then there'd be no point to it. I mean if like somebody's going to tell me what Basie record to play, that's kind of silly. I mean if Jo Jones told me to play it, that's fine. But I mean that's weird. I mean Herschel Evans died before I was born. Everybody else I met, most of them were close friends. I mean I even met Walter Page at six, and I think I met Jack Washington when he was in town when I was seven. It was real hello-goodbye quick with Jo Jones, but I was there. I remember the one with Page, on the street, I have no idea what street, "This man is Mr. Page, we call him 'Biggum,' you say 'hello Mr. Page.'" I said, "Hello Mr. Page." And he shook my hand and that was it. But that I

MR: That's great. When did you have an opportunity to do some writing in liner notes and all those kinds of things?

PS: Well I wrote some papers on jazz in college and I wrote one in high school. That's why I left the major music program in the New York City public school system. He actually thought I could play trumpet, he was wrong. I believe his name was Ralph Stein, he was my music teacher at Jamaica High School and he let me do my paper on Chick Webb in my sophomore year of high school. And I did a good job and he gave me a good grade. And then he got in trouble and I said let me out of here.

MR: Because of the subject matter he let you do?

PS: Yes. They didn't blame me, they could have, he got in trouble. And I said that's it. Let me out of here. I'll never take another music course in the school system. And that probably plants the seed of preventing me from overcoming my inferiority, which was for the best, but I was doing off on my own, and I guess I would be fifteen, and intentionally curtailing the music program in the New York City public school system for a righteous, accurate and correct reason. I was mad as hell. Still am obviously.

MR: Because they wanted you to do Bach or Beethoven or somebody like that?

PS: Yeah it was inappropriate. The teacher had approved the topic so it was him who got into trouble, not me, the grade stood. But I said I'll never take another music course. And that was besides — two more years, two and a half. And I never did. And I was mad. And they wouldn't let me talk about Duke Ellington in the classroom either. That continued at Columbia. So I said later for the music major at Columbia, the American history department was hiring me to teach jazz in their American history seminars. I said oh okay. I'm switching. And that's what I did. That's when my teaching career started.

MR: Oh. So the music department didn't want to know about it but the history department recognized it.

PS: They hired me off the street as an 18-year-old to come in and do guest lectures at Columbia University. And although they gave me only a little peso or something like that, I was paid. That wouldn't happen again for twenty years. Not quite that bad. Then there was a magazine, such an obscure publication that if you were to search for it even on the Internet for the rest of your life I'm sure you'll find no mention of it, called *Moonshadow*. And I reviewed the Newport Jazz Festival's first New York — when it came to New York in '72. And I guess that would be my first formal jazz publication, a little over thirty years ago, and probably the September '72 issue of *Moonshadow* if you want to really torture yourself.

MR: Do you have it?

PS: I found it. I found it in 1997, almost, over 25 years after its publication. And I was

was when I was 21. I was 21 when I wrote that review. And it's a good review. I'm pleased. I give myself — I'm harder on myself. You know since there's no other comparison that I'm putting on your film's record. I mean I was ready to tear me to shreds if I'd like took one misstep. And I took no missteps.

MR: Yeah. What attracts you — I'm skipping ahead years, but what attracts you to take on a reissue project?

PS: Well the importance of the music. The ability to make it a superior presentation to contemporary and potentially future audiences from the way it was initially presented, to document the information you know that might otherwise not be preserved. Those are three real reasons.

MR: And is it something that you usually initiate or is it a record company coming to you?

PS: Well originally I offered my services as a provider of the rarer stuff with the ability to convert it into a suitable sound for their reissues or first time issues. You know like I had actually a completely different system of doing 78 transfers in the mid-seventies, which I wonder if I ever again will be able to do and then find out if there was anything to it. But I used to do my re-mastering — KCR at that time was still off the air. This is how long ago it was because I'm sure it's over 25 years ago, was off the air for a couple of hours in the middle of the night in those years. It wasn't yet 24 hours a day. And I would do my re-mastering then on the premises and would throw it up to the exciter. There's a thing that triggers the transmitter having enough power to — it's sort of like a preamp for radio. And I would throw it through the exciter and then download, to use a modern term that was not used at the time, and transfer, tap off. I would bring it across from the exciter to a fairly good Scully two track machine, which was two track mono of course. I wish I had, if I was really smart I would have done a four track mono because they were mono. And that was my system then. And I've had so a little — so they said well you really know about the music, you write the notes. So I did a couple of liner notes, I did a couple of transfers, and then eventually I did a couple where I did both on the same project. And I would say that it was a very small component of my career. It was not happening that often, for another reason why it was so small, it was literally small as well as it was a small ad. Because I was doing the radio, I was trying to teach or trying to — I was still running the West End which we haven't talked about, a night club that had jazz seven nights a week for 17 years with very heavy hitting people like Jo Jones and others and Dizzy Gillespie and Benny Carter and others. And then I think the CD age is responsible for that. Because suddenly there was going to be more re-issuing. And by this time my reputation, I was a little bit older, I must have been in my early thirties now and so there's a guy who's got the rare stuff we don't have who can do the audio work, who can write

and also has producer capabilities. Well that's one stop shopping. Let's do him. And I think that's how it happened.

MR: You mentioned owning a club.

PS: I didn't own the West End.

MR: Well, running it.

PS: I ran it, that's for sure.

MR: Booking the musicians.

PS: I did everything there except play and on March 11 of '74 obviously I played at least one tune.

MR: How did they get you up there?

PS: What happened was a drunk wanted Milestones. And you know you have a lot of options when you have a drunk and one of them is see if you can probably get rid of him with sweetness rather than vinegar. I mean that was one of the great night club rules. You know like not that we had too many bouncing problems there, but the trick there is if you've got to put somebody out in the street bodily okay cool, you earned your pay. But if I think that's the way he's going out and you talk him out, that's a twenty dollar tip which in 1974 is a hell of a lot of money, or at least it was a reasonable amount of money for a tip. And so we were of the sweetness thing. So Frank Williams comes over to me and says, "I don't know this tune, Quinnichette's drunk all the time, what am I going to do?" And I said, "Well I'll play it." Because Frank Williams had — there were two times I played at the West End and both was because of the horn. I had probably already done the other one. Somebody had tried to sell Frank Williams a Colicchio horn, which is a very rare brass instrument. And I played it because it's like playing a Stradivarius if you're a violinist. A Stradivarius, a Colicchio cornet, very, very — and then I got into more trumpet, and remember I had not really officially stopped thinking about playing trumpet although I wasn't ever going to do it. And Frank Williams showed me. I go — Wynton goes heavy metal? Frank Williams' trumpet was the lightest trumpet I ever held. I always liked it, and he says, "You could play it if you want to." "No, no." But that night I played Frank Williams' trumpet and we got through it and the band got a tip if I'm not mistaken from the drunk. He did get quiet, it did work, so sweetness won that day. But then I knew I would never do that again. That was the two times I knew it was over, that was one. The more important one was Taft Jordan was one of my trumpet teachers. And he liked me a lot. And Charlie Shavers was dying of cancer and was starting to miss a lot of gigs. So Shavers called Taft to fill in for him. And Taft said, "No, but call my student." And I said, "Mr. Shavers, it's a real honor, but they expect to hear you, and if they get me they're not going to be happy." And when I put the phone down, I was still living in 1006

had to say yes regardless of consequences. So I said no, so obviously I knew what the answer was.

MR: Can you recall what you were able to pay these jazz artists when you were—

PS: Yeah I'm not proud of it but thankfully it was slightly above scale.

MR: Which was?

PS: Scale was $55.65, which is an unusual small higher salary for the leader.

MR: Oh right.

PS: Yeah usually it's double for the leader. But the scale, and also I paid the union dues. In fact I carved out that 802's AF of M, although David Sheldon can verify this, although I'm not a member of the musician's local, I was the delegate of the local 802 American Federal of Musicians for the address 2913 Broadway in Manhattan. Just for that address. And I went down to the union on Tuesdays and I think gave $28.45 every Tuesday. This is thirty years ago. And then the money got better. And of course certain acts — you know Jo Jones got more than that and Benny Carter — I shouldn't be telling Mr. Carter's salary, Benny Carter was getting a thousand dollars a night and a percentage. And Dizzy was getting a lump sum and he paid the band, and that would be more than a thousand then. I think scale by 1990, which would be the last year there was a formal scale, was $135.65. And we paid much more than that which is probably why it ended.

MR: You have a cover?

PS: We did from '84 on. And we went by minimum and bulk audience the first eleven years, which is a better system actually, for everybody. I mean the owners too. I mean there's a reason why I worked the West End for 17 years. I made money for the owner. But it's actually, you could see that I was a little awkward that the wages weren't overly great, but I'm not embarrassed by them. But in a sense I'm most proud of the West End episode because it's the only clear cut, well defined, start, middle and finish episode of my career in which the bottom line is so rosy in that the musicians who raised me were not old at the time that I started jazz at the West End. We are now in a position to appreciate that much better because they were largely in their late fifties, early sixties, late fifties. Jo Jones turned fifty, sixty rather, on October 7, 1971. So early sixties. Earle Warren was in his late fifties. He turned sixty on July 1, 1974. And so for the final stances of when they were not old, the last chapter of their career, they returned to the music that was their heart and played it in a very friendly atmosphere much nicer than most nightclubs, for reasonable money. And then they either died or retired. So the set concluded. It's a closed set and a positive one.

MR: It's fortunate that that existed.

PS: It was great. And it actually created a different type of relationship for me with me original teachers. Because they were still teaching but it was different. And the day to day life with them may actually be my greatest jazz credential.

MR: Can you recall the first time you heard Charlie Parker?

PS: You mean on record?

MR: Yeah.

PS: I think the "Night in Tunisia" on Yellow Dial label when Ross Russell came to close up things in 1955, if it was '55.

MR: Yeah. Did it make a particular impression on you at the time?

PS: I liked that one record. That's the one that I pulled out of — the records that he gave me I kept aside and didn't really get into until I was in junior high school. But a "Night in Tunisia" was in my regular stack. So there may be more Dizzy stories. But he's not on the record. The trumpet player is Miles Davis. And it's a 78 that tells you that he's on the record, the personnel is on the label.

MR: Yeah that's right in the little circle there. So you felt compelled to find out more about him?

PS: Well if the angle we're heading towards is why Bird, you know why does Charlie Parker become such a focal point in my career, I think I can explain that to you and I think it's two parts. One is my discovering that he's a good way to push jazz. Because you were mentioning a Hamilton College alumnus, Al Vollmer, he doesn't like bebop but he likes Charlie Parker.

MR: Interesting.

PS: And the guys at KCR who I was trying to get them to like the music that Al Vollmer liked, they liked Ornette Coleman because they liked Charlie Parker. I said ahh, I see how that goes. So that's part one. And then one of these people was a fellow named Irv Schenkler and he really produced the Charlie Parker festival on KCR because I really lit a fire for Bird. No he lit it himself, let's give Irv Shenkler one hundred percent of the credit. But the Charlie Parker Festival is the turning point of KCR's history. And that has a lot to do with Lennie Tristano. Because when Tristano — you see Tristano and I are great friends now that he's been dead for a quarter century. When he was alive, I mean I think I was not only scared of him, I don't think I liked him. Now I mean there are actually some doctoral theses that find us to be great friends and I guess we are, because I say so and he's not here to say whether we're not. But it was a very, very touchy situation that finally was resolved, the resentment I have of being yelled at by Lennie Tristano for basically the entirety of my adolescence and young adult life. Every day, yell. "Phil, you're such a nice young boy. Why would you want to listen to Dexter Gordon when you

Such a nice young fellow. Why waste your time?" And then I got on the radio and it got worse. "I never thought that you were stupid, Phil, I thought you were a beautiful cat. But that show you did today, Sonny Rollins. Play Bird." And it's a caricature now. I could do Lennie in voice thirty years ago. I mean and fool Lee Konitz. I did fool Lee.

MR: Did you really?

PS: Oh yeah, yeah. I can't now, it's just a joke now. But Tristano recognized the significance of the Charlie Parker festival and started a musician's network largely of his students telephoning and he single handedly in this regard, probably added ten to twenty thousand listeners of a devout nature to the KCR experiment, because of our week-long celebration of Charlie Parker in August and September of 1973. At the time, when I was at Columbia — I had graduated by this time — but when I was at Columbia my day gig was in the ID office. I did refereeing and the day gig. The ID office became my proverbial day gig to pay for my jazz life until August of 1980. For seven years that's how I paid my bills. So and it was registration for the fall semester of '73 at Columbia University while the Charlie Parker festival is going on. And there used to be a fire exit we used to walk out of the back door to quickly hit the street from KCR. So I dropped the record and it was "Scrapple from the Apple," the C take, November 4, '47. And it's on the air and it's like that's the record I love. My mother's favorite Charlie Parker record and Ben Webster's favorite Charlie Parker record so there you have it. But the record's grooving me and I'm thinking about it and hearing it and then I leave the station, I hit the fire exit and the record is gone. But the record is still in my brain because I'm playing it in my brain. And then I hit the street and the record was back, not just in my brain. This was very hot, it was summer and air conditioning wasn't so endemic. So people had their windows open and they were playing the Charlie Parker festival on the radio. I said, "We hit the jackpot." And then there was a guy from WABC — are you running out of time here with your film guy?

MR: Not yet.

PS: WABC — Steven K. Nenno was his name. So the Charlie Parker Festival, this is the turning point of KCR. I started February 2, of '70. I'm doing what I did already. But only a few people are listening. One of them is Tristano and he calls up to yell at me. But then I did the Charlie Parker Festival. Or really Irv Schenkler did the Charlie Parker Festival using my Charlie Parker chops. I'm the guy, he's the producer. That's a fair operation. And Tristano says, "Phil got the right idea." And so he calls the studio and says, "I'm calling you, you call five people I don't know." And then by whatever it was, I was sitting on a park bench with Howard McGhee on August 30, 1973 and we're listening to the Charlie Parker Festival eating ice cream. Because you could hear it in the streets. I

’73 I did the Fletcher Henderson Festival. And then okay, fine. And I get this phone call and says “I am Steven K. Nenno” — this is WABC who had a radio network at the time — “I’m in charge of, you know Arbitron is one thing but we do our own radio listings. And I need to talk to you. I’d like to come to WKCR and check out your operation.” So you know I’m 22 at the time, this could be big. He’s not the police, I’m not going to get arrested, or what could he do to me? So I go yeah. So he shows up and he literally sniffs around the joint and finally he tells me what’s the bottom line. He says, “Well you know I am Steven K. Nenno” he always said his name — the four times I heard him say his name with the middle initial — “I am Steven K. Nenno and I do these in-house ratings for the WABC radio people. And I had to see this for myself. You see in the first week of December of 1973 the seventh most listened to radio station in New York City was on a radio station I never heard of, a radio program I had never heard of, about a person I had never heard of, broadcast by a person I had never heard of.”

MR: And it got his attention.

PS: Yeah. I mean KCR had never popped up in his chart. So he had to go look in his FM code book to find it’s the Columbia University FM station. First of all FM stations didn’t pop up too often in the charts yet. So what are they doing? They had a Beatles festival? Whatever he thinks. First of all no, it’s not the Beatles, it’s not the Rolling Stones, there’s not a Jimi Hendrix memorial, it’s the Fletcher Henderson festival. Okay who’s Fletcher Henderson? He may be a coming pop college star. I better find out about him. No, the broadcast was by a college guy, Phil Schaap. Oh well who’s he? Well who’s Fletcher Henderson? What’s a Fletcher Henderson festival? How did they pop up seventh? You’ve never been on our listings ever. I mean you never even like a subscriber — however they — no one ever said WKCR to us. And this week we got seventh. You’re seventh. The seventh most listened to radio show that week in New York City. Who the hell are you and what is this all about? And then I knew that the Bird Festival was in August and September of ’73. The Fletcher Henderson Festival was the first week in December ’73. And that’s the thing. And Bird’s — Fletcher Henderson proved it but Bird did the work. Him and Lennie Tristano and Irv Shenkler.

MR: And you’re in year 31 now?

PS: No I was 22 when that happened. ’73.

MR: So how many years have you been on the air?

PS: I’ve been on the air from February 2 of ’70. For 3-1/2 years I had been at KCR at this transition. And from then it’s big time. It’s a big deal.

MR: Well before we—

PS: And that’s Bird. Like I say so Bird seems to be — so I dwelt on that and never

MR: Well obviously we're going to have to do another part two or part three here. But I wanted to ask you about a couple of things, and one was your definition of the rhythm section?

PS: Oh yeah. Jon Hendricks went crazy over that this morning here at the IAJE so I now realize that he wants me to put it down on paper, and to mail it to him. But you're getting a thing. But this is really, you know I was raised by Jo Jones the drummer in the Basie band, and someone we haven't mentioned yet which is Lawrence Lucie, the rhythm guitarist. He actually goes by Larry but he knows that everyone knows it's Lawrence Lucie. He just turned 95. And most of this is Lawrence Lucie. It's a little bit Jo Jones and a very little bit me, I'm sort of — but it's got a stamp of approval from jazz people including this morning, Jo Jones. And one of the mysteries is why jazz had a rhythm guitarist. Rhythm sections were different in those days. Most people don't understand it and couldn't duplicate it not because musicians aren't good. It's cause there's no way you're going to be able to reprise that rhythm section concept with no understanding. So this is — and this is a little bit too harsh. I'm cutting things — it's too concise, too pat, doesn't leave enough room for the obvious exceptions that prove numerous other rules. This is the story. So you've got four guys. You've got piano, bass, guitar — acoustic guitar — and drums. Okay the bass. The bass player is in charge of four. Meaning he's in charge of four four. The four four feel, that's the bass player's job. It's got to be four four. The guitar player is in charge — it's not in two four, but two four is always being played inside the four four. That's the guitar player's gig. The guitar player is in charge of two four, even though he's playing in four four as well. But he's in charge of not only the two four feel that's within the four four feel, there's sort of like two feels [scats] except I was doing more on one and three and that's the difference. I was singing a bass player from the twenties instead of a rhythm guitarist in the thirties. The guitar player stings two and four but subtly.

MR: Yeah. That's what I wanted.

PS: It can't be too bad, it has to be subtle, it has to be there. So the bass player is four, the guitar player is two four, the bass player is four four, the guitar player is two four, the guitar player is in charge of those unusual syncopation emphasises [sic] on two and four, okay? The drummer is in charge of swinging. He's swinging. He better swing or he's no good. Okay. The bass player and the piano — the bass player and the guitar player combined are in charge of making sure the drummer doesn't rush, since he's got to be so busy making sure it swings.

MR: Okay.

PS: And the piano player is in charge of the music.

PS: Pretty good though.

MR: Yeah, pretty good.

PS: And again, there are so many exceptions.

MR: So what does a drummer do to make sure he's swinging?

PS: That's up to the drummer. To try to sound like Jo Jones as best you can.

MR: Okay. Well I'm glad we got that first, that's cool.

PS: You got it first, yeah.

MR: That's cool.

PS: It's going — there are two things that I've got to do for Jon Hendricks when I get back to New York, he wants that written out, so you just send me a transcription you see, and I'm done.

MR: I will.

PS: And the second thing is he wants a very obscure Dizzy Gillespie record because he set some lyrics to "Scheherazade." That theme [humms] I can't sing it right now because I was thinking of something else and I don't sing well. And Dizzy is on a pop record where somebody had set lyrics to it a zillion years ago with an organist and playing odd figures behind it. And apparently Jon's got a gig and a record coming up so he needs to hear that. So I'm going to get that to him and the rhythm section thing. And that's the two things he wants.

MR: He's a great man.

PS: Yeah.

MR: Tell me about the Buckshot Marching Kazoo Orchestra.

PS: Oh well yeah, this is my connection to Hamilton. When I was — first launched the Countsmen, the Basie alumni band, I briefly — we had a good first year. If I thought that that was going to be the best year, this interview would never have happened. And one of the things is I created a college circuit for us so we would go to these college — right around the time the concept of the college circuit, which it fortified, among other things, Louis Armstrong and the All-Stars and Dave Brubeck and blah-blah-blah was about to disappear. But I didn't know that or at least I wasn't willing to admit it. So I was up at Hamilton in conjunction with a person I knew who was thinking of going to Hamilton. And when I got there I had my trumpet with me because I was still in the Columbia Marching Band. And we were known for being zany and weird. And the Columbia band was really known for doing some outlandish stuff in my day. I mean before I went to school for instance Kennedy showed up, John Kennedy, at the Harvard Columbia game in November of '63, early November of '63. And they just re-wrote the entire halftime show on the spot as a political satire and President Silverwater it was, the country will go

Kennedy loved it. Of course why wouldn't he, but I mean it wasn't the playing or the song but the whole riff. And so that's the band. And we, Columbia University Marching band is known for launching what is now a little bit more known which are these novelty orchestras that get pretty wild and non-musical, that the intellectual colleges do for their halftime shows. And when I got to Hamilton I discovered that they had one too. And it was even a little bit more skiffle than ours. It was the Aaron Burr Lucky Shot Marching and Kazoo Orchestra. And I thought that was funny. I thought it was a great name, great concept and I had my trumpet with me and I said I don't know any of your music and they said we don't have any music to show you and I said all right let's have fun anyway. And I went out there, was Hamilton playing Cortland State? They were playing, I think it was Cortland State, and I went out there and I played with the Aaron Burr Lucky Shot Marching and Kazoo Orchestra. And of course Alexander Hamilton went to Columbia you know. So we have our own feelings about this too.

MR: I see. And what year was this again?

PS: This would have been the fall of 1973.

MR: Okay. We'll have to tell some people about that at the school.

PS: In between the Charlie Parker Festival and the Fletcher Henderson Festival, I went to Hamilton, New York and played in a football game as a member of the Aaron Burr Lucky Shot Marching and Kazoo Orchestra.

MR: Wow. I wonder if it's on film, what do you think, Tim? Boy wouldn't that be something if we had a film of that.

PS: Yeah. I doubt you'd have a film of the halftime show. That'd be great.

MR: We'll have to look in the archives.

PS: Okay.

MR: Let me run a couple of names by you. Joe Williams?

PS: Well he was the reason why I met Jo Jones. When we were at the Randall's Island Festival in 1956 and Count Basie band was plenty hot and they had "Everyday I Have the Blues" which was a hit single, and the album "April in Paris," which I believe had come out as a big selling record, and my mother and I got backstage, and she was like holding my hand and this man started talking to her. In retrospect I now realize that he was probably hitting on my mother, and he said, "Well this is all very well and good we are backstage hearing Count Basie but if you play your cards right I can get you further backstage and you could actually meet Joe Williams." So my mother completely pops his balloon and says, "Well that's all very well and good but of course Jimmy Rushing was the only singer for the Count Basie Orchestra." Poof — he disappears. Jo Jones taps my mother from behind on the shoulder and says, "Madam I heard that, that was wonderful,

mister." I was five. It would be another fifteen years before anyone would ever call me mister again. "Okay mister, who's Prince Robinson?" "The tenor player in McKinney's Cottonpickers." I didn't have that voice. "The tenor player with McKinney's Cottonpickers." And Jo Jones announced to my mother that she had acquired a new babysitter. That was the breakthrough. So Joe Williams doesn't have too much to do in that story but he's the triggering mechanism.

MR: Okay. Interesting. That's a great story. What did you think of Cannonball and Nat?

PS: Well I love hearing that band because they were roaring and I like the rap on Cannonball's — onstage. I certainly came to understand that it was a little bit more pat than I wished it, you know. In the early sixties I thought that was ad lib.

MR: I'd like to think that but it probably wasn't.

PS: It wasn't. In the late sixties I'm catching a couple of more sets. Now maybe it was ad libbed in the early sixties and then it was pat. But I thought he was far more thoughtful about the music than his fame in the Ramsey Lewis area kind of allowed people to know. He's sort of seen as one of the springboards of the pop-fusion developments that are going to occur. Nowhere near as important as Miles but he's there and he lasts until '75, and his band did go a little bit electric and of course and had its "Mercy Mercy Mercy," you know a hit. But I saw him as one of the great intellectuals who were also roaring roots players, which is the ultimate combination from a jazz studies point of view. You don't have to intellectualize this music but if you want to study it you've got to know something about it. That kiddy record that Cannonball did, that's killing.

MR: Yeah.

PS: How come you know so much?

MR: You talking to me?

PS: Yeah.

MR: Well I'm a saxophone player.

PS: Yeah but Cannonball, a kiddy record.

MR: I have it.

PS. You're a heavyweight. You went up sixty notches. There's a building here with 7,000 people who think they know that record and they don't.

MR: Well I have my heroes.

PS: That Cannonball kiddy record, you're one of my new heroes now.

MR: Oh gosh well. That's saying a lot. And you know I really hope that — we'll have to get together again. I come to New York on occasion.

PS: All right.

MR: And I really wish I could pick up your radio station where we live.

PS: Yeah well we're having a lot of problems, you know, we were in the World Trade Center and I'll leave something on the record here because I feel that strongly about it, but I'll make it a joke. I'll close with a joke. Some jazz musicians like to do that. WKCR has been mistreated by Columbia University, the FCC and Osama Bin Laden and Bin Laden is in third place.

MR: All right. Enough said. Well maybe next time around we'll understand why. Well I want to thank you for all the things you've done in this business.

PS: Why thank you. Did you get what you wanted for your thing?

MR: I did for part one.

PS: Okay well did I talk too much then? I apologize, that's one of my trademarks. You proved that I'm me.

MR: Okay. Thank you so much.